

**Mapping the Conceptual Boundaries Between Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) and
Corporate Social Advocacy (CSA):
A Topic Modeling and Word Embedding Analysis via *PR-Embed***

Jiacheng Huang¹, Bree Hurst², Luke W. Capizzo³, and Alvin Zhou✉¹

¹Hubbard School of Journalism and Mass Communication

University of Minnesota, Twin Cities

²School of Advertising, Marketing & PR

Queensland University of Technology

³Department of Advertising + PR

Michigan State University

Author Note

✉ Corresponding author: Alvin Zhou, alvinxyz@umn.edu.

Abstract

This study examines how *corporate social responsibility* (CSR) and *corporate social advocacy* (CSA) have been conceptualized in public relations scholarship. Using structural topic modeling and word embedding, we analyze 4,128 full-text articles published between 2004 and 2024 in six major public relations journals. The analyses identify six CSR- and CSA-related topics, revealing growing topical overlap. Word embedding results show increasing linguistic convergence since 2020 despite CSR and CSA works' distinct citation networks. Topic affinity analysis further indicates that CSR research follows established thematic routines, whereas CSA scholarship remains comparatively diffuse and exploratory. We argue that maintaining definitional clarity is essential to preserve each concept's theoretical and practical value as their boundaries continue to converge. Methodologically, we introduce and open-source *PR-Embed*, an interactive toolkit that provides access to all topic-level and word embedding results from this twenty-year corpus.

Keywords: CSR, CSA, Public Relations, Computational Methods, Word Embedding, Structural Topic Modeling

Mapping the Conceptual Boundaries Between Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) and Corporate Social Advocacy (CSA):

A Topic Modeling and Word Embedding Analysis via *PR-Embed*

The concept of corporate social responsibility (CSR) has developed into a substantial and fruitful area of research in public relations scholarship since its emergence in the early 1980s (Ji et al., 2020). Since this time, CSR studies in public relations have evolved to encompass a diverse range of research themes from different managerial perspectives (Goodwin & Bartlett, 2008).

5 Given the extensive body of CSR research in public relations, many review papers have been conducted (e.g., Golob et al., 2013; Goodwin & Bartlett, 2008; Ji et al., 2021; Lee, 2017). While these reviews have synthesized major developments, CSR scholarship in public relations remains dynamic, with emerging frameworks introducing new—and sometimes competing—perspectives. One such perspective is corporate social advocacy (CSA).

10 The concept of CSA first appeared in public relations vernacular in 2014 and has since been the focus of numerous conceptual and empirical studies. The initial definition of CSA articulated a clear conceptual distinction from CSR, emphasizing engagement that is (1) polarizing and (2) less directly related to an organization's core function or purpose (Dodd & Supa, 2014). However, this distinction has become increasingly blurred, as many scholars argue
15 that CSR itself has expanded to include politicized issues (Ashby-King et al., 2025). Despite these originally proposed differences, scholars acknowledge that CSR and CSA do—and potentially should—overlap in their applications, measures, and intended prosocial outcomes (Ashby-King et al., 2025). This raises a central question: as the boundaries between CSR and CSA continue to blur, are scholars truly investigating distinct concepts?

20 Unlike CSR, reviews of CSA scholarship remain limited, largely because most CSA research has been published only within the past decade. Although emerging studies have begun to examine CSA's conceptual boundaries and applications (e.g., Rim et al., 2020; Waymer & Logan, 2021), no comprehensive review of the CSA literature has yet been conducted to parallel the extensive review tradition associated with CSR. Without a systematic analysis of CSA

25 scholarship, it remains unclear whether CSR and CSA represent distinct constructs or overlapping applications of similar ideas.

To examine the similarities and differences between CSR and CSA in public relations scholarship, this study provides the first large-scale, systematic comparison of the two concepts across six major public relations journals. Our primary goal is to clarify how CSR and CSA have
30 been used and operationalized in peer-reviewed research and to assess whether they function as empirically and conceptually distinct constructs. To achieve this, we employ computational text analysis, specifically structural topic modeling (STM) and word embedding, which allows us to analyze patterns of language use across thousands of full-text articles. Beyond addressing substantive questions about conceptual overlap and divergence, this study also contributes
35 methodologically by demonstrating how word embedding can be integrated with topic modeling in public relations research. To support transparency, reproducibility, and cumulative inquiry, we introduce and open-source *PR-Embed*,¹ an interactive platform that enables scholars to explore topic structures, semantic relationships, and additional concepts beyond those examined in this study.

40 Our analyses yield several theoretically consequential findings. At the concept level, CSA is semantically closer to political terms than CSR, which can make it appear like “CSR in political contexts.” However, vector arithmetic analyses show that CSA is not reducible to generic political CSR but instead centers on processes of politicization that are distinctively communicative. At the topic level, CSR is more closely associated with corporate communication, media relations, and
45 organization-centered practices, whereas CSA aligns with advocacy, legal positioning, authenticity concerns, and strategic adaptation in conflict, reflecting an engagement-centric and socially mediated orientation. Longitudinally, CSA scholarship remained sparse until after 2018 and accelerated sharply after 2020, though still at levels far below CSR; STM classification further reveals the presence of CSA-like work prior to the widespread adoption of the CSA label.

¹ Link redacted for peer review, since the website may reveal author details. If reviewers and editors deem it necessary for review purposes, we can show the link during the next round of revision.

50 We also document growing topical overlap and increasing linguistic convergence between CSR
and CSA since 2020, despite their distinct citation networks. Finally, topic affinity analysis shows
that CSR research follows established thematic routines, whereas CSA scholarship remains
comparatively diffuse and exploratory. Taken together, these findings suggest that maintaining
definitional clarity is essential to preserve each concept's theoretical and practical value as their
55 boundaries continue to converge.

This paper is structured as follows. First, we provide an overview of public relations
research on CSR, followed by a review of CSA scholarship and ongoing issues of definitional
clarity between the two concepts. We then present the data and methods, including an overview of
word embedding as a methodological approach for public relations research. The results and
60 discussion are structured around the three research questions guiding this study. Drawing on our
findings, we conclude by calling on scholars, editors, and journal reviewers to prioritize
consistency, clarity, and deliberation when using and applying the two terms, to ensure they retain
their conceptual value rather than devolving into primitive terms—concepts for which scholarly
definitional clarity has been lost (i.e., Chaffee, 1991; Lane, 2020).

65 **Theoretical Framework**

Research Review Scholarship in Public Relations

Public relations has a strong history of research review scholarship that has mapped the
discipline over many decades. Beginning with the work of Pasadeos (Pasadeos & Renfro, 1992;
Pasadeos et al., 2010) and continued by Ki (Ki et al., 2019, 2021), a bibliometric approach laid the
70 foundation for an empirical understanding of prior research in the field. The bibliometric method
articulates central topics covered, author contributions, and citations, generally through manual
coding. Subsequent methods have utilized network analysis as a mindset to connect and cluster
citational patterns to understand scholarly trajectories (e.g., Ji et al., 2020; Kim et al., 2014;
Morehouse & Saffer, 2018, 2019). Some have paired network and cocitational analysis
75 approaches (Page & Capizzo, 2021).

Most recently, STM has added additional depth to research review scholarship by

examining both broad and specific topical areas (e.g., Page et al., 2023, 2024; Song et al., 2020; Yue et al., 2025). Using an STM approach has the benefit of including every word from scholarship as part of the analysis, while prior methods relied on keywords, abstract analysis, or
80 citational patterns. While imperfect, STM provides the most complete picture of specific areas of scholarship through this approach. Zhou et al. (2023) have used this technique to map distinct areas—subparadigmatic clusters—of public relations research, based on finding language that demonstrates connectivity. This process includes the computational method of topic modeling, but also a qualitative thematic analysis and clustering component, similar to the data condensation
85 aspects of qualitative data analysis and reduction to synthesize across central themes (e.g., Miles et al., 2020). For example, as Page et al. (2023) examined in the crisis communication space, related terms such as apologia, bolstering, and rhetorical reflected the crisis communication perspective of image repair (e.g., Benoit, 1997) in contrast to terms such as attribution, crisis history, and preventable, which indicated work in a situational crisis communication theory
90 context (e.g., Coombs, 2007). In this way, STM can be utilized to track the linguistic breadcrumbs that help to identify distinct strands of research and articulation of different concepts.

One limitation of STM, however, is that it tends to separate topics even when they refer to closely related constructs. To overcome this limitation, in addition to employing STM, we also employ word embedding, an increasingly popular technique in computational linguistics that
95 captures semantic relatedness despite differences in surface form (Buehling et al., 2025; Mikolov et al., 2013). Thus, this paper also offers a new methodological approach for public relations research. The next sections provide an overview of the two areas of theoretical comparison for this paper: CSR and CSA.

Corporate Social Responsibility in Public Relations

100 Drawing on Carroll's (1979, p.500; see also Carroll, 1991) seminal definition, CSR can be understood as the "economic, legal, ethical and discretionary [later termed philanthropic] expectations that society has of organizations at a given point of time." As Lee (2017)—in their content analysis of the status of CSR research in public relations—summarized, the core idea

behind CSR is that organizations are expected to fulfil societal obligations, and importantly, that
105 these obligations go beyond what is required under the law or beyond simple profit maximization.

Despite scholarly origins in the management literature, research suggests CSR has been
part of the strategic communication and public relations vernacular since the early 1980s (Ji et al.,
2020). Since this time, there have been a number of reviews of CSR within public relations
research, including Goodwin and Bartlett's (2008) review of 40 articles published in three public
110 relations and communication journals; Golob et al.'s (2013) systematic review of 90 articles;
Lee's (2017) content analysis of 133 articles published in 11 journals from 1980 to 2015, and
more recently, Ji et al.'s (2020) network and bibliometric analysis of 290 articles published
between 1980 and 2018 across 16 communication journals. Collectively, these reviews provide
insights into, amongst others, the evolution/growth of CSR research in communication journals,
115 key authors (and networks of authors), key journals, citations (including foundational literature),
and research themes (i.e., management function, communication management, and relational
management, as per Goodwin & Bartlett, 2008).

Overall, scholars suggest that CSR has had a long and varied history across many
disciplines since the concept—as we know it—first emerged in the 1950s (Carroll, 1979, 1991,
120 1999; Carroll & Brown, 2023; Carroll & Shabana, 2010; Golob & Bartlett, 2007). Since this
time, it has matured into its own field in both academia and practice (Carroll, 2025), though some
scholars have argued that there is still significant room for further maturation (Ji et al., 2020), and
that research on CSR remains “both sketchy and comprehensive” (Maak & Pless, 2021, p. 6).
Research also suggests there are a number of competing and complimentary frameworks and
125 theories to CSR that have arisen over the last few decades, resulting in critique about whether
some of these concepts are truly unique or simply CSR rebadged or repurposed under a different
name (for an overview of some of these, see Carroll, 2021; Carroll & Brown, 2023). Of particular
interest to this paper is CSA.

The Emergence of Corporate Social Advocacy

130 Unlike CSR, which evolved in a business and management context with communicative components as part of its broader picture, corporate social advocacy (CSA) has grown from within the public relations literature. It was developed by Dodd and Supa (2014, 2015) in response to the emergence of organizational engagement in polarizing social issue discourse, with a particular interest in issues unrelated to an organization's core function (e.g., Rim et al., 2020).
135 Specifically, Dodd and Supa (2014) defined CSA as "an organization making a public statement or taking a public stance on social-political issues" (p. 5) and argued that it spanned the "boundary between two areas: strategic issues management and corporate social responsibility" (p. 2). In articulating why CSA is related, but distinct, to both issues management and CSR, Dodd and Supa (2014) focused on three main arguments: (1) the socio-political issues being addressed by the
140 organization are not connected or appear to be of relevance to the organization; (2) the socio-political issues are controversial and could therefore alienate organizational stakeholders; and (3) an emphasis on financial outcomes.

Of the three, Points 1 and 2 are typically used by scholars to distinguish between CSR and CSA, with arguments that CSR efforts, by comparison, often reflect: (1) low stakes or
145 noncontroversial issues; as well as (2) issues both relevant and less relevant to an organization's business purpose or industry. Issues management tends to focus on issues of contentious nature, but is inclusive of issues across the spectrum from highly related to an organization's purpose to wholly unrelated (i.e., Coombs & Holladay, 2018). By contrast, for example, Nike's stances on social justice issues (e.g., Waymer & Logan, 2021) reflect CSA practices because Black Lives
150 Matter is polarizing in the U.S. and the stance is not inherently related to selling athletic apparel. Of course, organizations can and should find points of connection and narratives that reflect authentic issue engagement, which can be constructed by decades of commitment to issues, as has been illustrated via Ben & Jerry's (Ciszek & Logan, 2018; Martinez Gonzalez & Capizzo, 2025). Thus, authentic stances, which have been shown to improve consumer outcomes (e.g., Dodd &
155 Supa, 2014; Zhou & Dong, 2022), are perceived as more genuine in their purpose. Logan (2016)

notes that the Starbucks “Race Together” campaign, which involved baristas interrupting the morning routines of customers to discuss racial justice, demonstrated the company’s authenticity of commitment to Black Lives Matter despite its general consideration as a failed exercise.

Despite—or, perhaps, because of—several missteps, Starbucks leadership’s ongoing commitment to racial justice as an organization has demonstrated genuineness and commitment to the cause through CSA.

However, Ashby-King and colleagues (2025) have recently argued that “[a]s a theoretical framework, CSA has been critiqued as a narrow concept that does not reflect the reality that an organization’s communication takes place in relation to organizational actions and the complex socio-political and ideological contexts the organization is operating within” (p. 2-3). More specifically, they state that since organization communication related to CSR, CSA, and corporate political advocacy (CPA; i.e., You & Cheng, 2025) “does not occur in isolation,” a more “holistic” (Ashby-King et al., 2025, p. 1), approach is needed due to the current socio-political context, in which CSR-related issues can, in some instances, be considered controversial or polarizing. Thus, while CSA was originally conceived as a separate, but related, concept to CSR, it appears these boundaries are now blurring.

Lack of Definitional Clarity

While Dodd and Supa (2014) defined CSA in a way that clearly distinguished it from CSR, scholars have frequently blurred the lines between the two concepts by (1) adapting CSR measures for CSA research (e.g., Kim et al., 2025; Lim & Young, 2021) and (2) pushing the definitional boundaries of CSA (Ashby-King et al., 2025; Kim & Meganck, 2025). Additionally, Kim and Meganck (2025) explain that, in their work “CSA is defined as the public communications and initiatives that companies undertake regarding specific socio-political matters, aiming to shape public opinion and/or influence relevant policies” (p. 191). They cite literature around corporate political advocacy (Wettstein & Baur, 2016) to justify the broadening of the definition of CSA to include non-controversial topics—essentially stepping into a space traditionally held within CSR.

Therefore, this paper begins the process of a holistic investigation into the application of

these two related terms in scholarship. Specifically, this paper seeks to empirically understand how the public relations literature has conceptualized CSR and CSA, and whether there are concrete differences in the operationalization of these two terms. To do this, this paper address three interrelated research questions:

- **RQ1:** How have CSA and CSR been conceptualized in public relations scholarship?
- **RQ2:** What do the longitudinal trends tell us about CSA versus CSR research in public relations scholarship?
- **RQ3:** Within public relations scholarship on CSA and CSR, what are the similarities and differences in key topics and what does this mean for avenues for future research?

Overview of Method

To examine how the two streams of literature on CSR and CSA have developed, converged, or diverged over the decades, we compiled a comprehensive dataset of research output on these topics published in major public relations journals. We archived full-text articles through web scraping, covering six public relations journals over the past twenty years. Table 1 summarizes the scope of this dataset. This effort exceeds the coverage of comparable prior studies, which either spanned less than a decade or examined only two journals (e.g., Yue et al., 2025; Zhou et al., 2023). The resulting corpus was processed using standard text-preprocessing techniques, including lemmatization and stopwords removal.²

Beyond expanding the scope of data, this study also innovates on the methodological front. Prior research, as cited above, has commonly employed structural topic modeling (STM) to identify latent themes in large corpora. However, STM relies on a bag-of-words approach, which represents documents by word frequencies while disregarding context (Roberts et al., 2014).

Although computationally efficient and theoretically useful for topic-level interpretation, this representation limits the ability to link semantically similar but lexically distinct terms. This

² Lemmatization reduces words to their base dictionary form (e.g., “running” → “run”). Stopword removal drops very common function words (e.g., “on,” “the,” and “because”) that contribute little topical signal.

limitation is especially problematic for the present research, which contrasts terms that are conceptually related yet seldom used together. For example, scholars in corporate communication traditions may consistently use “CSR,” whereas papers drawing on environmental communication concepts or originating from certain regions may prefer “sustainability” or “ESG.” Because authors typically choose one label and apply it consistently throughout a paper, these terms may rarely co-occur. As a result, STM may separate them into different topics even when they refer to closely related constructs.

To address this, we employ word embedding, an increasingly popular technique in computational linguistics that learns distributional representations of words by modeling the contexts in which they appear, for which we will provide a brief primer shortly. This approach recognizes terms such as CSR, ESG, and sustainability as similar to one another, capturing their semantic relatedness despite differences in surface form (Buehling et al., 2025; Mikolov et al., 2013).

Rather than treating STM and embedding as substitutes, we integrate their complementary strengths: STM’s capacity for topic discovery and embedding’s ability to capture semantic nuance. We begin with the more familiar STM approach to establish a foundation, then extend the analysis using word embedding as part of a hybrid framework.

Structural Topic Modeling

STM is a text analysis method that identifies latent thematic structures within large document collections. Unlike simple keyword searches or frequency-based approaches, STM models the co-occurrence patterns of words to uncover topics, then estimates the probabilistic mixture of these topics within each document (Roberts et al., 2014, 2019). In short, it reveals what topics, represented by keywords, are present in a document and how prominently they feature (e.g., 60% focusing on Topic A and 40% on Topic B). One strength of STM over earlier topic modeling techniques is its capacity to incorporate document-level metadata as covariates. Following established research frameworks (e.g., Page et al., 2024), we include journal and publication year as covariates to uncover how the literature on CSR and CSA has evolved over

time and across journals.

While STM can output topic distributions for each document, it does not determine the optimal number of topics—that is, how many topics public relations scholars write about. This requires both expert judgment and diagnostic evaluation. We first estimated STM models with topic numbers ranging from 10 to 150 and assessed their semantic coherence, exclusivity, and residuals. Six models met the diagnostic criteria, all clustering around 90 topics. However, computational analysis is not theory-neutral; human interpretation remains essential. Thus, a team of public relations researchers with diverse methodological and substantive expertise then independently evaluated these models and unanimously selected $k = 93$ as the final model, which provided the best balance between coherence, interpretability, thematic richness, and reduced filler topics. Subsequently, the author team collaboratively labeled each topic by reviewing top words and representative documents. Through this process, we identified six topics explicitly relevant to CSR and CSA, with their labels and top words presented in Table 2. Our Appendix A and replication materials provide full transparency for the STM and topic labeling processes, showing the list of all 93 topics, their most representative words, diagnostic results, and alternative models.

We used two variables derived from STM in our core analyses. The first is the proportion of CSR and CSA topics in each of the 4,128 publications, expressed as percentages. For each article, we used the proportion of the CSA topic as the CSA Topic Proportion (P_{csa}), and summed the proportions of the five CSR topics to create a CSR Topic Proportion (P_{csr}). Higher values reflect a stronger topical focus on CSR or CSA. For example, Austin and Gaither (2017) (perceived motivations for corporate social responsibility initiatives in socially stigmatized industries) was identified to have 79.47% P_{csr} and 1.83% P_{csa} , while Parcha (2023) (conceptualizing the relationship between corporate social advocacy and political polarization) had 11.27% P_{csr} and 76.27% P_{csa} respectively. These proportion scores allowed us to quantify the degree to which each paper addresses CSR or CSA themes, supporting both longitudinal trend (RQ2) and topic affinity (RQ3) analyses.

They also provided an intuitive basis for classifying papers. Since CSR topic proportions

averaged 4.79% across all documents, we defined papers above this value as “CSR papers”; similarly, we labeled those above the CSA average (0.64%) as “CSA papers.” Some publications exceeded both thresholds, indicating a dual focus, as in Zhou (2021) (communicating corporate LGBTQ advocacy: a computational comparison of the global CSR discourse). Others fell below both, such as Ndone et al. (2022) (emotional crisis communication: the effects of CEO’s expression of guilt and anger on organizational reputation). Accordingly, we classified the 4,128 publications into four categories: CSR-focused (colored green in visualizations thereafter), CSA-focused (red), dual-focus (purple), and neither (black). We use the “-related” terminology to refer to papers that relate to CSR or CSA, regardless of their focus on the other topic. In other words, CSR-related papers are the union of CSR-focused and dual-focus papers.

Word Embedding

Before describing our application of word embedding in this study, we briefly review the method, as it has not been widely employed in strategic communication research. Word embedding is a natural language processing (NLP) technique that represents words as vectors in a continuous, high-dimensional space (Mikolov et al., 2013; Pennington et al., 2014). Unlike traditional bag-of-words models that treat each word as a discrete unit and focus solely on frequency, the word embedding model captures semantic relationships by placing words with similar contexts close to one another in the vector space (Joulin et al., 2017). Beyond NLP, word embeddings have been widely applied in sociology (Kozlowski et al., 2019), management (Cong et al., 2025; Wu, 2023), marketing (Yang et al., 2022), and related fields. For example, while most word embedding models operate in high-dimensional spaces, we can simplify this by projecting words onto the two-dimensional xy -plane: if the word “laptop” has a vector of $[x=.5, y=.3]$, the word “computer” may have a vector of $[x=.51, y=.29]$, with their proximity reflecting their similar meanings. This contextual positioning allows us to capture nuanced relationships between related terms. For example, while STM treats “disclosure” and “disclose” as entirely separate entities, the word embedding method represents them as nearby vectors and understands their syntactic relationships.

Word embedding also captures meaningful associations through vector arithmetic. Just as vectors represent geometric relationships, word embeddings—being vectors themselves—encode relationships between words. A well-known example (Figure 1 Panel A) is the analogy “man is to woman as king is to ____,” which is solved by computing the vector operation $\vec{\text{king}} - \vec{\text{man}} + \vec{\text{woman}}$, yielding a result closest to $\vec{\text{queen}}$.

These high-dimensional spaces can also be custom-trained to capture domain-specific linguistic phenomena. For instance, distinct models may be developed for specialized fields such as medicine or law. Figure 1 Panel B illustrates how, when trained on social science literature, embedding can more effectively capture relationships between key methodological terms. A comparable practice is how organizations around the world are now training their own large language models (LLMs), which are based on word embedding, to better understand and generate text in their specific domains.

We apply the same logic in our study by training our own *Word2Vec* models—a widely used 300-dimensional word embedding technique developed by Google—on different data sources (e.g., Kozlowski et al., 2019). The first model was trained on the full corpus of 4,128 papers published between 2004 and 2024, capturing linguistic patterns across two decades of public relations scholarship. This all-encompassing model offers a holistic view of the field’s discourse. The second set consisted of 21 annual models, each trained on publications from a single year. These yearly models capture temporal shifts in vocabulary and semantic associations, allowing us to see how key concepts—such as the relationship between CSR and CSA—change over time. More methodological details are provided in Appendix B.

In our core analyses, we primarily used embedding similarity as the key variable. Operationalized as vectors’ *cosine similarity* (θ)—the cosine of the angle between two vectors—embedding similarity quantifies the degree of semantic relatedness between words, documents, or sets of documents (Kozlowski et al., 2019). Values range from -1 (maximally dissimilar) to $+1$ (maximally similar), with 0 indicating orthogonality. Figure 1 Panel C illustrates this concept with the laptop/computer example, where a small angle between the two word vectors

results in high cosine similarity. For document-level analyses, we computed each paper’s average embedding by aggregating the embeddings of words in that article (Figure 1 Panel D). This allowed us to assess similarities between documents and, by extension, between groups of documents. For example, we could measure how the average embedding of literature published in 2024 shifted from that of 2004.

To illustrate the robustness of this method, which is relatively new to the field, and its consistency with STM, we contrasted how the two approaches quantify the degree of linguistic alignment with CSR and CSA topics. For each paper, we computed its embedding similarity with the word “CSR” (θ_{csr}) and “CSA” (θ_{csa}) in our two-decade embedding model. We then tested the correlations of θ_{csr} and θ_{csa} with the document’s CSR/CSA topic proportions derived from STM (P_{csr} and P_{csa}). Across all papers, both were significantly correlated ($r_{csr} = .43, p < .001$; $r_{csa} = .67, p < .001$). For transparency, in Appendix C, we provided the top 10 most-CSR and most-CSA papers identified by both approaches.

Analytical Steps

To answer RQ1, which asks how CSR and CSA have been conceptualized so far in public relations scholarship, we performed both word-level and topic-level analyses. At the word level, we first identified the top 20 words most semantically similar to “CSR” and “CSA” in the two-decade word embedding model to observe how and where each concept is situated in semantic space. We then moved beyond this proximity analysis by performing vector arithmetic, similar to the examples shown in Figure 1 Panels A and B. Although CSA is often viewed as a political variant of CSR, this interpretation remains contested in the literature. To empirically examine how public relations scholars have conceptualized the relationship between CSR and CSA, we conducted a series of exploratory vector operations. Specifically, we tested how adding political attributes to CSR or removing philanthropic and environmental components would shift its semantic position relative to CSA. These operations allowed us to probe the conceptual boundaries between CSR and CSA and provided an empirical basis for investigating their semantic divergence.

At the topic level, we extended our embedding analysis by mapping STM topics onto a semantic axis defined by CSR and CSA. For each topic, we first averaged the embeddings of its 40 most representative words from STM, generating a vector that captures its position in embedding space, shown in Figure 1 Panel D. Next, we constructed a semantic spectrum by connecting the vectors for CSR and CSA, forming a conceptual axis—illustrated as the dotted coordinate system in Panel E. Along this axis, we projected all remaining topics, quantifying their alignment with either end of the spectrum. Panel F provides illustrative examples of these projections, with each dot representing a selected topic positioned along the CSR-CSA spectrum. This approach enables us to identify the types of topics that CSR and CSA are proximally associated with in public relations scholarship, offering empirical insight into the kinds of thematic terrain that surround each construct.

To address RQ2, which examines the longitudinal development of CSR and CSA scholarship, we conducted three analyses. First, we analyzed the growth trajectories of CSR- and CSA-focused and dual-focused papers through annual publication trends. We also tracked direct keyword mentions of “CSR” and “CSA” in articles. Second, leveraging word embedding, we explored how the semantic relationship between CSR and CSA has evolved: are these concepts converging or diverging in academic discourse? Drawing on Figure 1 Panel C as an analogy, we measured the embedding similarity between “CSR” and “CSA” across the 21 year-specific Word2Vec models. In addition to this word-level analysis, we evaluated the average embedding similarities between pairs of CSR- and CSA-related papers each year to assess whether they are becoming more linguistically aligned over time. Third, we examined the citation patterns of CSR- and CSA-focused papers to understand their influence and interconnections within the literature—do they draw from the same foundational sources, or do they reflect epistemologically distinct traditions? By analyzing their reference lists, we identified the most frequently cited works within each group and highlighted their differences, providing insight into the core texts and conceptual lineages that shape CSR and CSA scholarship.

To answer RQ3, which seeks to uncover the thematic landscape surrounding CSR and

CSA research and to reveal hidden research opportunities that CSR and CSA scholars may have overlooked, we conducted a topic affinity analysis based on the framework proposed by Page et al. (2023). Topic affinity measures the extent to which one topic co-occurs with another, adjusting for how commonly the second topic appears overall. This normalization addresses the possibility that high co-occurrence might stem from the second topic's general popularity rather than a specific association. For example, CSA and OPR may frequently co-occur not because CSA research is particularly focused on OPR, but because OPR is broadly prevalent in the field. By normalizing affinity scores based on the destination topic's average prevalence, we isolate true topical preferences. We applied this method to assess how CSR and CSA topics preferentially attach with each of the 87 remaining topics. Comparing these 87 topics' CSR/CSA affinity scores to their averages, we categorized them into four groups: "CSR Only," "CSA Only," "Both CSR and CSA," and "Neither CSR nor CSA." This typology helps surface the latent thematic habits in CSR and CSA research and highlights underexplored avenues for future inquiry.

Extending Featured Theory with Proposed Method

RQ1: Semantic Relationships Between CSR and CSA

To address RQ1 about what constitutes CSR versus CSA in public relations scholarship, we examined both word-level and topic-level representations.

First, we identified the top 20 words most semantically similar (i.e., geometrically adjacent; cf. Figure 1 Panel C) to the two seed words. Shown in Table 3 with their embedding similarities in parentheses, CSA's most similar terms were CPA ($\theta = .486$), sociopolitical (.421), activism (.411), femvertising (.403), controversial (.402), and authenticity (.399). In contrast, CSR was most closely associated with sustainability (.537), sus (.496), ESG (.460), philanthropic (.440), initiatives (.436), and corporate (.418).³ There was no overlap between the two sets.

This suggests that CSA is semantically closer to political terms, giving the impression that

³ Table 3 includes these abbreviations: sus = sustainability (Jain & Winner, 2016); CD = corporate diplomacy (Ingenhoff & Marschlich, 2019); CA = corporate ability (Wu et al., 2024); PwOM = positive word-of-mouth (Troy et al., 2023); EVPs = employee volunteer programs (Shi, 2022); PIOC = partake-in-our-cause (Lim et al., 2015); CSRC = CSR communication (Georgiadou & Nickerson, 2020). Baur, Morsing, and Supa are last names commonly cited in-text by examined papers.

CSA might simply be CSR in political contexts. However, this assumption does not hold under closer vector arithmetic analysis (cf. Figure 1 Panels A and B). Specifically, computing $\vec{\text{CSR}} + \vec{\text{politicized}}$ placed CSA as the nearest neighbor ($\theta = .47$), confirming that CSA involves a distinct dimension of politicization absent from standard CSR literature. In contrast, $\vec{\text{CSR}} + \vec{\text{political}}$ yielded sustainability (.49) and sociopolitical (.48) as top results, with CSA close behind (.47).

These findings suggest that CSA is not reducible to generic political CSR but rather centers on processes of politicization, a distinctively communicative phenomenon that opens future directions for theorizing how issues become politicized, who drives this process, how it is communicated, and its implications for stakeholders. In Appendix C, we further show that removing the environment/philanthropy dimension from CSR and adding political/politicized terms again placed CSA among the top results ($\theta_{\text{political}} = .39$; $\theta_{\text{politicized}} = .38$).

To further clarify CSR and CSA as understood by public relations scholars, we conducted a topic-level embedding analysis (cf. Figure 1 Panel F). While most topics clustered near the conceptual middle ground between CSR and CSA, the extreme values delineate their conceptual boundaries. Shown in Figure 2, CSR is more closely associated with corporate communication and media relations and anchored in organization- and practice-centric themes. The most CSR-leaning topics include media relations (projection = .083), corporation (.081), Europe (.077), internal communication and language (.072), PR training (.071), and institution (.069). These topics emphasize corporate structures, internal processes, and stakeholder routines that align with CSR's organizational tenor and managerial stewardship.

CSA, by contrast, aligns with advocacy, legal positioning, authenticity concerns, and strategic adaptation in conflict. Prominent CSA-leaning topics include political PR (projection = -.199), authenticity (-.149), activism (-.135), contingency (-.125), and legal issues (-.117). These topics foreground position-taking and public contestation rather than managerial stewardship. Additional CSA-oriented topics, including message testing (-.110), emotional appeal (-.111), and Twitter (-.102), further reflect an advocacy-oriented, engagement-centric, and socially-mediated

character that distinguishes CSA from CSR.

RQ2: Longitudinal Trends of CSR and CSA

Figure 3 visualizes how the two streams of literature have developed over time. At the keyword level (Panel A), CSR has consistently dominated CSA in textual frequency across two decades. CSR mentions appeared steadily throughout this period, with notable growth beginning around 2010 and peaking in 2019, when public relations scholars wrote the word “CSR” more than 4,500 times in a year. CSA, however, remained largely absent until the mid-2010s—coinciding with Dodd and Supa’s (2014, 2015) conceptualization of the term—with substantial growth emerging only after 2018 and accelerating sharply after 2020, though still at levels far below CSR. This logically reflects the lag in scholarly publishing after the initial emergence of the term in 2014.

At the paper level (Panel B1), the STM-based classification reveals intriguing patterns: some CSA-related papers existed before 2018, despite not consistently using the term “CSA.” In other words, while the scholarly convergence on CSA as a label occurred relatively recently, public relations research had begun addressing CSA-like themes before the term itself gained traction. One example is “communicating corporate LGBTQ advocacy: a computational comparison of the global CSR discourse” mentioned earlier, which aligns conceptually with CSA despite not using the term explicitly. To facilitate such retrospective recognition, Table 4 highlights pre-2018 examples of CSA-like work, suggesting that while the CSA terminology has emerged relatively recently, its underlying themes have been present in the field for much longer.

Panel B2 visualizes the underlying data from Panel B1 to show overlap between categories. CSR-related work has remained dominant throughout the timeline, but CSA-related papers have steadily increased, with the intersection between CSR and CSA (i.e., dual-focused papers) growing significantly after 2020. This trend indicates that while CSA has developed into a distinct area of inquiry, many scholars continue to frame it in conjunction with CSR. Notably, dual-focused papers have grown rapidly in recent years, suggesting that CSA research is increasingly situated within or linguistically aligned with the conceptual framework of CSR. In

other words, CSA scholarship seems to have become more CSR-like over time.

To further investigate this growing convergence, we examined the evolving semantic relationship between CSR and CSA using word embedding. Panel C1 tracks the cosine similarity
450 between the terms “CSR” and “CSA” across yearly word embedding models. While similarity fluctuated over the years—dipping sharply in 2019 and again in 2021 and 2022—the overall trend is upward. From a baseline of .314 in 2018, the similarity rose to .469 by 2024, indicating that the two constructs have become more semantically aligned over time in public relations literature.

However, this keyword-based analysis has a limitation: the sparse usage of the term “CSA”
455 before 2018 makes it difficult to assess earlier relationships. To overcome this, Panel C2 shifts to a document-level perspective. We computed the average embedding similarity between all possible CSR-CSA paper pairs, identified using STM results, within each year. Overall, public relations scholarship is stylistically homogeneous, with average document similarities near .948. The similarity between all CSR and CSA papers combined (across all years) is slightly higher, at .951.
460 Against this baseline, yearly similarities fluctuate but generally remain close, with the exception of 2018, where similarity dropped to .909, coinciding with CSA’s more distinct emergence in the literature. This pattern suggests that when the CSA concept first emerged, scholars emphasized its distinctiveness relative to CSR. After this dip, similarity values rebound and stabilize, suggesting that while CSA introduced a temporary semantic divergence from CSR, the two concepts continue
465 to be framed in largely overlapping ways.

An evident asymmetry emerges in the citation patterns between CSR- and CSA-focused papers, as shown in Table 4. CSR research in public relations journals draws extensively from foundational works in business ethics, management, and marketing, with frequently cited sources spanning from the late 1970s through the 2010s. These include Carroll’s influential frameworks
470 (Carroll, 1979, 1991, 1999), studies on consumer behavior (Sen & Bhattacharya, 2001; Yoon et al., 2006), and communication strategies for CSR messaging (Du et al., 2010; Morsing & Schultz, 2006; Morsing et al., 2008).

By contrast, CSA-focused papers rely on a distinctly separate body of literature, rooted

primarily in communication and public relations scholarship. These references are considerably
475 more recent, with a pronounced concentration post-2015. Frequently cited works include case
analyses of corporate activism campaigns, such as Ben & Jerry's engagement with Black Lives
Matter (Ciszek & Logan, 2018), experimental studies on the effects of CSA messaging (Dodd &
Supa, 2015), and investigations into audience polarization (Rim et al., 2020). Theoretical
foundations in this domain draw from dialogic communication theory (Kent & Taylor, 2002;
480 Taylor & Kent, 2014) and crisis communication frameworks (Coombs, 2007).

What is particularly noteworthy is the complete lack of citation overlap between the two
domains. Specifically, none of the top 10 publications most frequently cited by CSR-focused
papers are cited even once by CSA-focused work, and vice versa. This mutual exclusivity
underscores the degree to which CSR and CSA research in public relations have developed along
485 separate intellectual paths, shaped by divergent theoretical foundations and disciplinary
affiliations. While CSR remains anchored in business and management logics, CSA research
orbits communication theory and case-driven studies of corporate advocacy. This bifurcation
presents a sharp contrast to the embedding analyses presented earlier, which suggest growing
linguistic convergence between CSR and CSA scholarship.

490 **RQ3: Charting Habitual Minds When Writing About CSR and CSA**

To address RQ3 regarding the thematic tendencies of CSR and CSA scholarship, we
examined topic affinity, defined as the co-occurrence of two topics normalized by the overall
prevalence of the destination topic (i.e., a non-CSR, non-CSA topic). This approach reveals the
habitual associations each domain maintains: which topics authors regularly invoke and which
495 they tend to overlook when engaging with CSR or CSA.

A comparison of the horizontal and vertical axes in Figure 4 reveals that CSA exhibits
lower average affinity with other research topics compared to CSR. This suggests that CSA
scholarship, still in its formative stages, lacks the established topical routines—or “habitual mind,”
referring to the patterned co-occurrence of concepts and preferred topic pairings that have become
500 conventional in a research area (Page et al., 2024)—that characterize CSR research. While CSR

studies are anchored in a consistent set of well-established topics, CSA research traverses a more diffuse and exploratory intellectual landscape. Using the dotted lines denoting mean affinity scores, we classify the topics into four groups: (1) topics prominent in both CSR and CSA, (2) topics strongly associated with CSR but less so with CSA, (3) topics strongly associated with CSA but less so with CSR, and (4) topics marginal in both CSR and CSA.

Topics Prominent in Both CSR and CSA. These themes represent shared intellectual terrain and recurring points of reference. Notable examples include *corporation*, *brands*, *legitimacy*, *reputation*, and *quantitative methods*. These topics frequently structure scholarly framing and reflect the conceptual common ground between CSR and CSA.

Topics Strongly Associated with CSR but Less So with CSA. This group encompasses several established subfields where CSA research remains underdeveloped. Examples include *risk communication*, *critical public relations*, *discursive approaches*, and *international PR*. These underexplored domains represent clear opportunities for CSA scholars to expand their analytic scope and engage more deeply with frameworks already well-integrated in CSR literature.

Topics Strongly Associated with CSA but Less So with CSR. Topics in this category emphasize advocacy, relational engagement, and identity dynamics. They include *emotional appeal*, *networks*, *contingency*, *sports and tourism*, and *influencer*. Although these themes are conceptually relevant to CSR, they remain comparatively underrepresented in that body of work, revealing potential areas for theoretical extension—or as areas of divergence.

Topics Marginal in Both CSR and CSA. Finally, several thematically and methodologically important areas show low affinity across both domains. These include *qualitative methods*, *public diplomacy*, *image repair*, and *government communication*. It is not necessarily surprising that public diplomacy and government communication showed low affinity, given the traditional focus on corporations in both CSR and CSA research. However, the limited attention to qualitative inquiry, in particular, suggests a methodological imbalance that could be redressed through increased use of interpretive, ethnographic, or discourse-analytic methods, and in doing so, contribute to expanding the conceptual and methodological diversity of CSR and

CSA scholarship.

Introducing *PR-Embed*

Finally, to make this embedding-based approach accessible, transparent, and reproducible, we developed *PR-Embed*, an open-access, interactive website that integrates word embedding and structural topic modeling results to facilitate conceptual exploration in public relations scholarship. All findings from this study can be directly reproduced and verified using live interactive features on the site.

The website provides four tabs corresponding to different analytical levels: word-level exploration, paper-level exploration, topic-level exploration, and topic projection.

In the word-level exploration tab, users can input a word (e.g., “CSR”) to view its nearest semantic neighbors, as well as the most closely related papers based on word and paper embeddings. Users can also input two words (e.g., “CSR” and “CSA”) to visualize their semantic relationship over time using the yearly word embedding models. This tab further includes a word equation explorer, which allows users to define their own vector arithmetic operations (e.g., $\vec{csr} - \vec{environment} + \vec{political}$) and examine the resulting semantic outputs.

In the paper-level exploration tab, users can search for a paper by title published between 2004 and 2024 in the six public relations journals. The website then displays the paper’s topic composition based on the STM results, along with its most similar papers (i.e., nearest neighbors) identified using paper embeddings.

In the topic-level exploration tab, users can select any STM topic to view its representative keywords and then explore the most representative papers associated with that topic.

In the topic projection tab, users can define a semantic axis using two focal words (e.g., “CSR” and “CSA”) and visualize how all STM topics are projected along this conceptual axis.

By consolidating STM and word embedding within a single computational framework, *PR-Embed* functions as both a research infrastructure and a methodological exemplar for embedding-based analyses in communication research. Beyond its immediate application to CSR-CSA scholarship, *PR-Embed* offers a generalizable framework for examining other concepts

555 in public relations, advancing computational interpretability by visualizing abstract conceptual relationships and making semantic structures empirically traceable.

Conclusions

Our analysis suggests that CSA's focus on position-taking and public contestation—relative to CSR's greater emphasis on managerial stewardship—is what sets CSA apart from CSR. More specifically, consistent with the original conceptualization of CSA by Dodd and Supa (2014), 560 CSA's emphasis on polarization and politicization has, at least within public relations scholarship during the period studied, functioned as a key point of conceptual distinction from CSR.

At the same time, our analysis also reveals growing linguistic convergence between CSR and CSA. Since 2020, we observe an increase in “dual-focused” papers, that is, studies that frame 565 CSA in conjunction with CSR. In other words, CSA appears to be becoming more CSR-like over time (or, conversely, CSR within public relations scholarship appears to be becoming more CSA-like), particularly with respect to topics, methods, and measures. Notably, despite this convergence, CSA and CSR remain shaped by divergent theoretical foundations and disciplinary affiliations: CSA is firmly situated within public relations and communication scholarship, 570 whereas CSR continues to be grounded in management, business ethics, and marketing literatures.

Our analysis further suggests that although CSA had become a relatively established concept in public relations scholarship by 2018, it lacks the established topical routines—or “habitual mind”—observed in CSR research. More specifically, CSR scholarship tends to be anchored in a consistent set of well-established topics, whereas CSA research spans a more diffuse 575 intellectual landscape. Given the relative newness of CSA compared to CSR, this pattern is not surprising, as it likely reflects scholars' ongoing efforts to explore and expand the concept. At the same time, it suggests that greater attention may need to be paid to the boundaries of CSA scholarship.

Taken together, the findings of this paper reveal that CSR and CSA retain distinctive 580 conceptual roots and topical emphases within public relations scholarship, even as areas of conceptual overlap and convergence continue to expand.

The convergence between CSR and CSA can have both positive and negative implications. Conceptual evolution is a natural feature of scholarly inquiry: ideas, concepts, and theories are borrowed across disciplines; established measures are adapted; and conceptual boundaries are tested and refined in response to empirical realities. From this perspective, convergence can be productive, enabling scholars to explore issues traditionally associated with one domain through the lens of the other. At the same time, scholars, reviewers, and editors must remain attentive to the consequences of these choices. As CSR and CSA increasingly converge, the risk is that both concepts may lose theoretical distinctiveness and analytical utility.

Polarization and politicization, which were central to the original conceptualization of CSA and supported by our findings, represent a particularly important conceptual boundary between CSA and CSR. Attending to these dimensions may offer one avenue for scholars, editors, and reviewers to preserve meaningful distinction between the two constructs. This focus also opens clear directions for future CSA research, including theorizing how issues become politicized, who drives these processes, how politicization is communicated, and what its implications are for stakeholders.

The divergent theoretical and conceptual roots of CSR and CSA further shape future research trajectories. CSA scholarship has largely developed within public relations, with relatively limited influence from adjacent fields. Introducing insights from outside the discipline may therefore support the continued evolution and refinement of CSA. Conversely, given CSR's origins and its sustained engagement with scholarship beyond public relations, future work on CSR would benefit from continued dialogue with the broader business and management literature, which may help further delineate, or in some cases consolidate, conceptual boundaries.

One illustrative example is provided by Archie Carroll's recent update to his highly-referenced three-dimensional model of CSR. In revising the third dimension from "social issues involved" to "stakeholders involved," Carroll (2025) argued that this change reflects the emergence of issues management as a distinct field and developments in stakeholder theory. Specifically, Carroll noted that issues management grew out of increasingly turbulent social,

political, and consumer environments, focusing on major organizational issues and crises (p. 6).

610 While he acknowledged that social issues management remains “intimately connected” to CSR (p. 6), the revision implicitly recognizes that issues management is not synonymous with the social issues dimension as originally conceived. This recalibration suggests a departure from the social issues management approach that some public relations scholars (e.g., Ashby-King et al., 2025) have proposed as a bridge between CSR and CSA, underscoring the importance of periodically
615 reassessing conceptual boundaries as fields evolve.

Research review scholarship plays a central role in this process by providing empirical and integrative perspectives on how ideas develop, overlap, and diverge over time (e.g., Pasadeos & Renfro, 1992; Zhou et al., 2023). Such work enables scholars to improve the coherence, quality, and impact of a research domain (Ji et al., 2020). In this case, our findings point to the ongoing
620 need for conceptual clarity and careful distinction between CSR and CSA to preserve their unique meanings and operationalizations. This does not imply the necessity of singular definitions, but rather calls for deliberate and transparent use of each term by authors, editors, and reviewers. Thoughtful integration, such as selectively drawing on one construct to inform the study of the other, remains possible, but must be undertaken in ways that protect the integrity of both concepts.

625 Finally, from a methodological standpoint, our analysis highlights a relative scarcity of qualitative research across both CSR and CSA scholarship, raising potential concerns for theoretical depth and interpretive richness. Thoughtful qualitative work encourages scholars to engage with theory and practice in ways that enable deeper exploration of topic, via its strengths in embracing complexity and diversity, generating meaning through cooperation, understanding
630 emergent ideas, views and/or different processes, its highly holistic and contextualized nature, and the ability of the research to be reflexive (Daymon & Holloway, 2011). Such work, therefore, may help explain why CSR and CSA appear to be converging in theory—and whether this convergence reflects practice—or alternatively, may surface additional distinctions and nuances that remain obscured in large-scale quantitative analyses.

Opportunities and Limitations of Method

To our knowledge, this is the first study in public relations scholarship to apply word embedding as a methodological tool for large-scale textual analysis, offering both new opportunities and certain limitations. The use of word embedding allows researchers to quantify meaning rather than mere word occurrence. Specifically, this study demonstrates how word embedding can capture the deeper semantic proximity and conceptual overlap within the literature that usually remain invisible to frequency-based approaches such as structural topic modeling. For example, while STM can quantify the number of CSR- and CSA-related papers over time at the document level, it cannot trace concept-level variation in meaning. By contrast, the embedding approach enables examination of semantic relationships at the word level, revealing that the conceptual distance between CSR and CSA has narrowed over the years. Such a finding would not be possible using STM alone.

However, instead of choosing one method over another, we demonstrate how embedding models can complement existing methods such as STM. The hybrid framework, which combines topic- or paper-level patterns with word-level semantic relationships, can be applied more broadly to map conceptual boundaries in other areas of public relations research, such as CSR and ESG, CSA and CPA, engagement and dialogue, or transparency and disclosure, as examples.

Despite these methodological advances, several limitations should be acknowledged. First, the dataset is restricted to six public relations journals, meaning the results primarily reflect how CSR and CSA are discussed within the public relations research community. Consequently, the findings may not generalize to how these terms are conceptualized or evolve in related disciplines such as business ethics, management, or marketing. Second, this analysis focuses exclusively on scholarly discourse and does not examine whether the observed conceptual convergence between CSR and CSA aligns with real-world communication practices or public understanding.

Expanding data coverage would also address a third limitation: the relatively short time span during which CSR and CSA have been concurrently developed and discussed, which constrains robust inference about their convergence or divergence patterns.

Suggestions for Future Research

While the present study advances methodological innovation by combining embedding with STM and developing *PR-Embed*, several avenues remain open for future research. First, subsequent studies could expand the dataset beyond public relations journals to include scholarship in adjacent fields such as business ethics, management, marketing, and communication studies. A broader corpus would allow for a more comprehensive mapping of how CSR and CSA are conceptualized across disciplinary boundaries and could clarify whether the observed convergence is a field-specific phenomenon or a wider trend in organizational research.

Second, future work should explore whether the semantic convergence observed in academic texts mirrors real-world communication practices. Integrating practitioner discourse—such as corporate sustainability reports, campaign messaging, and social media posts—would allow researchers to test how scholarly ideas translate into public communication and whether organizations construct meaning in similar ways.

Third, from a methodological standpoint, subsequent research could enhance the *PR-Embed* framework by incorporating contextual embeddings (e.g., BERT or CLIP models). Finally, qualitative or mixed-method approaches could complement computational analysis, helping to explain why semantic convergence occurs and how scholars or practitioners interpret conceptual boundaries in situ.

Importantly, the development and open-source release of *PR-Embed* align with broader efforts toward transparency and reproducibility in computational strategic communication research (Zhou & van der Meer, 2024). By combining theoretical sensitivity with computational precision, this framework encourages future scholarship that moves beyond surface-level text patterns toward a deeper understanding of how concepts evolve and interrelate within public relations and strategic communication scholarship. We hope future research can follow suits, not only publishing their findings but also sharing computational models, visualizing backend data, and developing user-friendly interfaces to facilitate cumulative knowledge building.

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Table 1*Overview of the 20-Year Full-Text Dataset across Six Public Relations Journals (2004–2024)*

Journal	Collected	Removed	Final	Total Words	Years
<i>Corporate Communications: An International Journal (CC)</i>	800	78	722	4,144,671	2004–2024
<i>International Journal of Strategic Communication (IJSC)</i>	421	20	401	2,852,185	2007–2024
<i>Journal of Communication Management (JCM)</i>	576	48	528	3,222,198	2004–2024
<i>Journal of Public Relations Research (JPRR)</i>	467	72	395	2,932,836	2004–2024
<i>Public Relations Inquiry (PRI)</i>	280	69	211	1,506,547	2012–2024
<i>Public Relations Review (PRR)</i>	2,139	268	1,871	9,433,945	2004–2024
Total	4,683	555	4,128	24,092,382	2004–2024

Note: Removed articles are non-peer-reviewed publications, such as acknowledgment of reviewers, erratum, call for papers, and book reviews. All authors manually reviewed the dataset to delete these entries.

Table 2*CSA and CSR Topics from STM Topic Discovery*

Topic No. and Label	Top Keywords
Topic 10	Report Disclosure Sustainability Firm Financial Annual
CSR Reporting	Company Social Disclose Governance Voluntary GRI
Topic 21	CSR Company Motive Consumer Fit Corporate Altruistic
CSR Fit	Perceive Skepticism Initiative Attribution Association
Topic 46	CSR Social Corporate Responsibility Activity Stakeholder
CSR Approaches	Business Communication Practice Philanthropic SMEs
Topic 53	Corporation Environmental Business Corporate Green
Environmental CSR	Sustainable Label Friendly Recycle Eco Pollution
Topic 88	Industry Food Public Issue Pharmaceutical Tobacco
Deviant Industry in CSR	Health Drug Smoke Stigmatize Regulatory Safety
Topic 42	Issue CSA Advocacy Social Political Stance Action
CSA	Boycott Controversial Nike Value Statement Activism

Table 3*Words Most Adjacent to CSA and CSR in Embeddings*

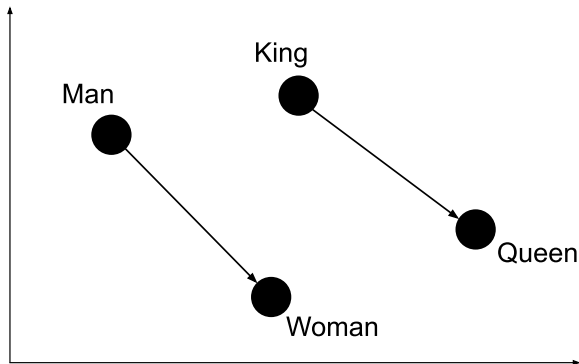
Rank	CSA	CSR
1	CPA (0.486)	Sustainability (0.537)
2	Sociopolitical (0.421)	Sus (0.496)
3	Activism (0.411)	ESG (0.460)
4	Femvertising (0.403)	Philanthropic (0.440)
5	Controversial (0.402)	Initiatives (0.436)
6	Authenticity (0.399)	Corporate (0.418)
7	Stances (0.393)	Philanthropy (0.392)
8	Nike (0.381)	Environmental (0.389)
9	OREO (0.380)	CD (0.377)
10	Stance (0.377)	Corporations (0.371)
11	Baur (0.374)	Morsing (0.365)
12	Congruence (0.372)	CA (0.356)
13	PWoM (0.370)	EVPs (0.356)
14	PIOC (0.368)	CSP (0.355)
15	eCSR (0.365)	DEI (0.354)
16	Brandstanding (0.365)	Company (0.352)
17	Supa (0.363)	Prosocial (0.350)
18	Advocacy (0.361)	Companies (0.350)
19	LGBTQ (0.357)	Postcrisis (0.349)
20	Attenuated (0.356)	CSRC (0.348)

Table 4
Articles Most Cited by CSA- and CSR-Focused Papers

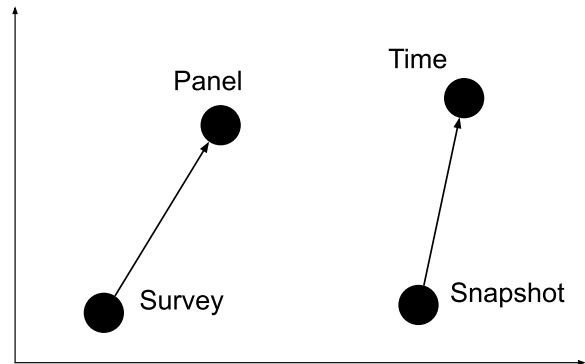
Title	Journal	Year	CSA Cites	CSR Cites
Most Cited Work in CSA-Focused Papers				
Challenging the dialogic promise: How Ben & Jerry's support for Black Lives Matter fosters dissensus on social media	Journal of Public Relations Research	2018	33	0
Testing the viability of corporate social advocacy as a predictor of purchase intention	Communication Research Reports	2015	28	0
Onward into more fog: Thoughts on public relations' research directions	Journal of Public Relations Research	2006	23	0
Polarized public opinion responding to corporate social advocacy: Social network analysis of boycotters and advocates	Public Relations Review	2020	21	0
Social issue qua wicked problems: The role of strategic communication in social issues management	Journal of Communication Management	2018	21	0
Protecting organization reputations during a crisis: The development and application of situational crisis communication theory	Corporate Reputation Review	2007	20	0
Dialogic engagement: Clarifying foundational concepts	Journal of Public Relations Research	2014	20	0
"Why should we care about marriage equality?": Political advocacy as a part of corporate responsibility	Journal of Business Ethics	2015	18	0
Toward a dialogic theory of public relations	Public Relations Review	2002	18	0
Corporate social advocacy as public interest communications: Exploring perceptions of corporate involvement in controversial social-political issues	Journal of Public Interest Communications	2019	18	0
Most Cited Work in CSR-Focused Papers				
Maximizing business returns to corporate social responsibility (CSR): The role of CSR communication	International Journal of Management Review	2010	0	91
Corporate social responsibility communication: Stakeholder information, response and involvement strategies	Business Ethics: A European Review	2006	0	67
Does doing good always lead to doing better? Consumer reactions to corporate social responsibility	Journal of Marketing Research	2001	0	57
Corporate social responsibility. Evolution of a definitional construct	Business and Society	1999	0	50
The effect of corporate social responsibility (CSR) activities on companies with bad reputations	Journal of Consumer Psychology	2006	0	49
The pyramid of corporate social responsibility: Toward the moral management of organizational stakeholders	Business Horizons	1991	0	47
The 'Catch 22' of communicating CSR: Findings from a Danish study	Journal of Marketing Communications	2008	0	45
The impact of perceived corporate social responsibility on consumer behavior	Journal of Business Research	2006	0	42
A three-dimensional conceptual model of corporate performance	Academy of Management Review	1979	0	37
Transferring effects of CSR strategy on consumer responses: The synergistic model of corporate communication strategy	Journal of Public Relations Research	2011	0	36

Figure 1
Word Embedding Illustrations

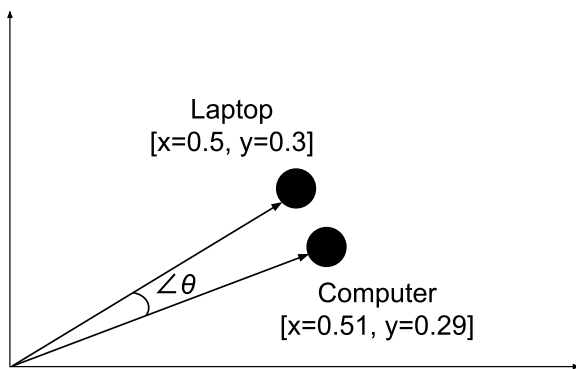
A. King - Man + Woman $\approx$ Queen



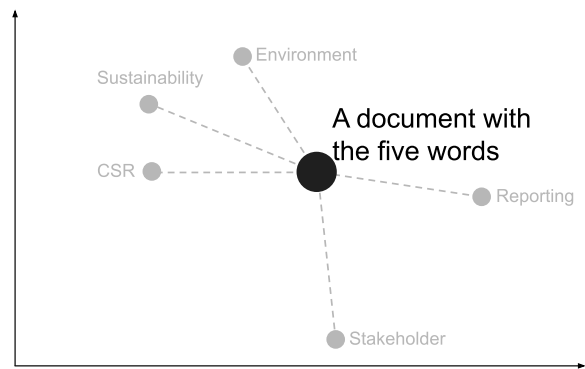
B. Survey - Snapshot + Time $\approx$ Panel



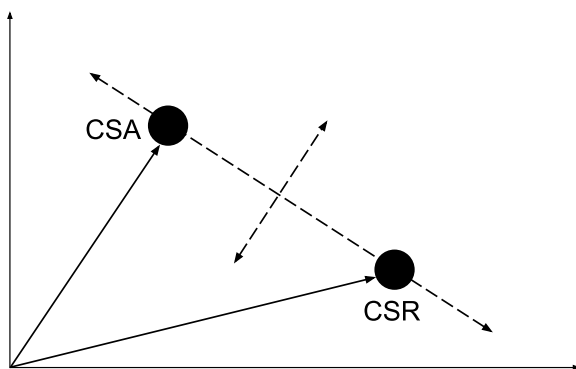
C. Small $\angle\theta$, High $\cos \theta$ (cosine similarity)



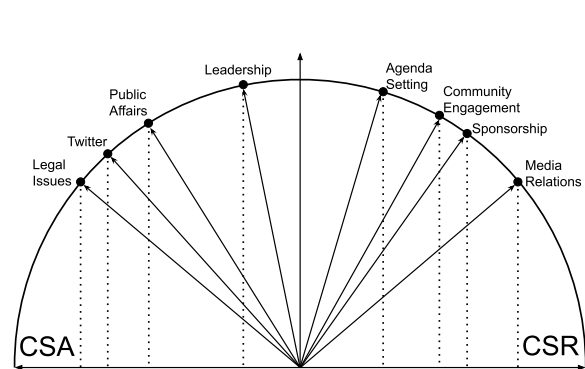
D. Average of word embeddings in a document



E. Creating a CSA-CSR Spectrum



F. Research Topics Projected



Note: Word embeddings typically exist in high-dimensional space; we use 2D for illustration. Panel A shows a semantic analogy. Panel B depicts domain-specific embedding. Panel C illustrates cosine similarity. Panel D shows document embedding via word vector averaging. Panel E forms a CSA–CSR semantic axis. Panel F projects example topics onto this axis.

Figure 2
Topic Distribution Along the CSA-CSR Spectrum

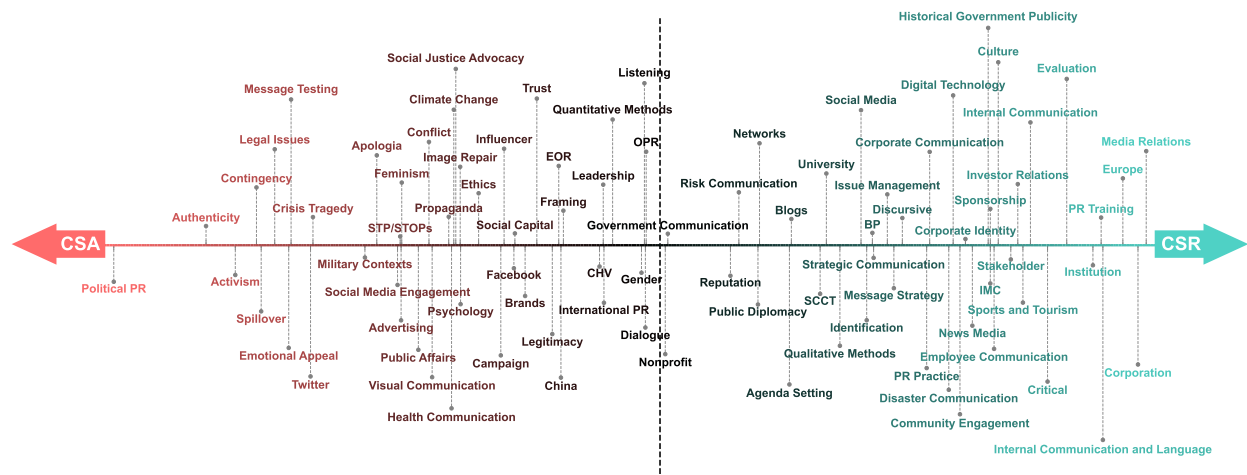


Figure 3
Longitudinal Trend of CSA and CSR Scholarship



Notes. Panel A shows yearly mentions of “CSA” and “CSR.” Panel B1 reports CSA- and CSR-related paper counts based on STM results. Panel B2 (2013-2024) uses Venn diagrams to show overlap. Panel C1 plots yearly cosine similarity between the two words “CSA” and “CSR.” Panel C2 shows average similarity between CSA- and CSR-related papers, with CSA-CSR baseline and all-paper baseline shown in comparison.

Figure 4
CSA/CSR Topic's Affinity Towards Other Research Topics

